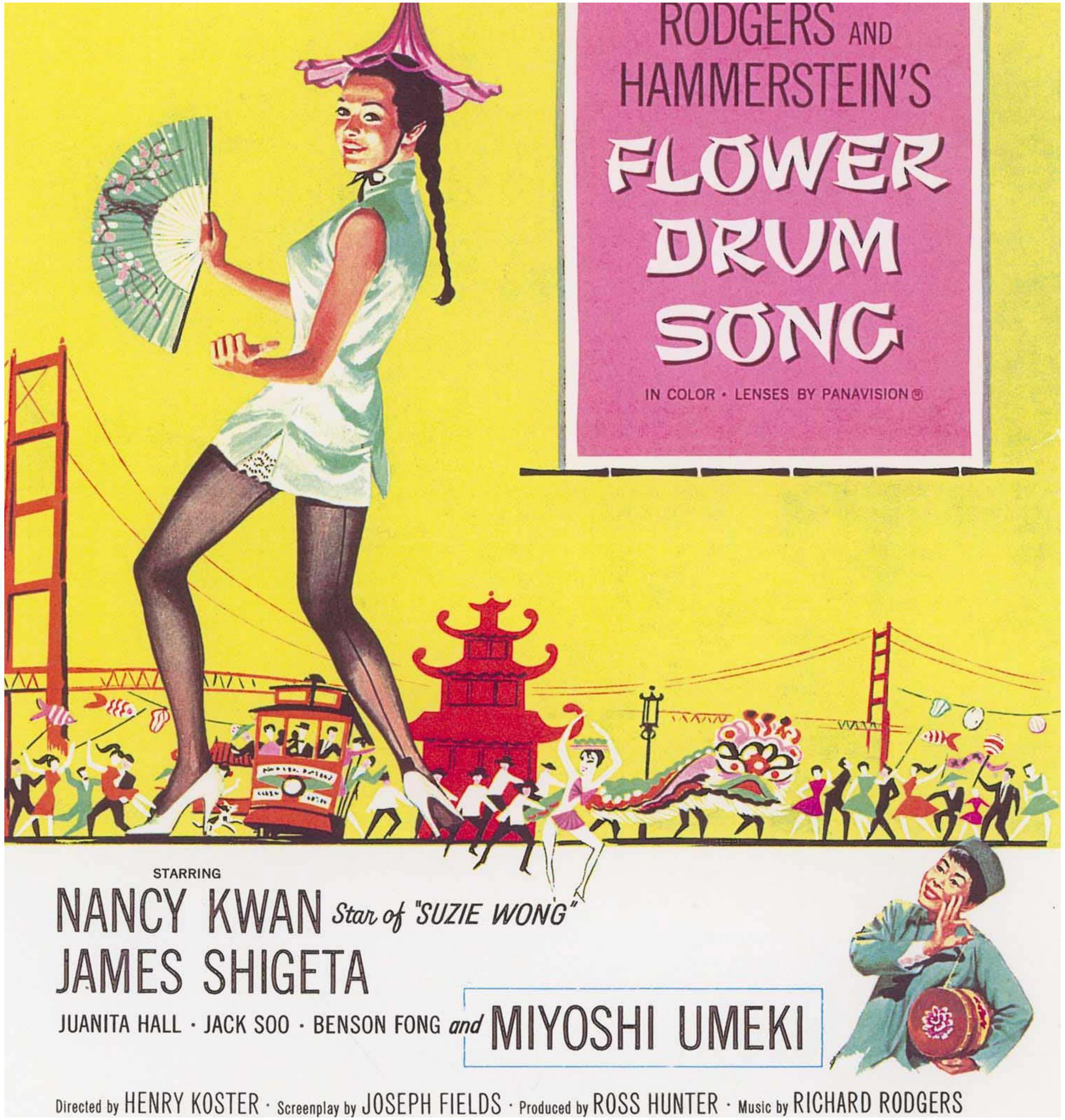
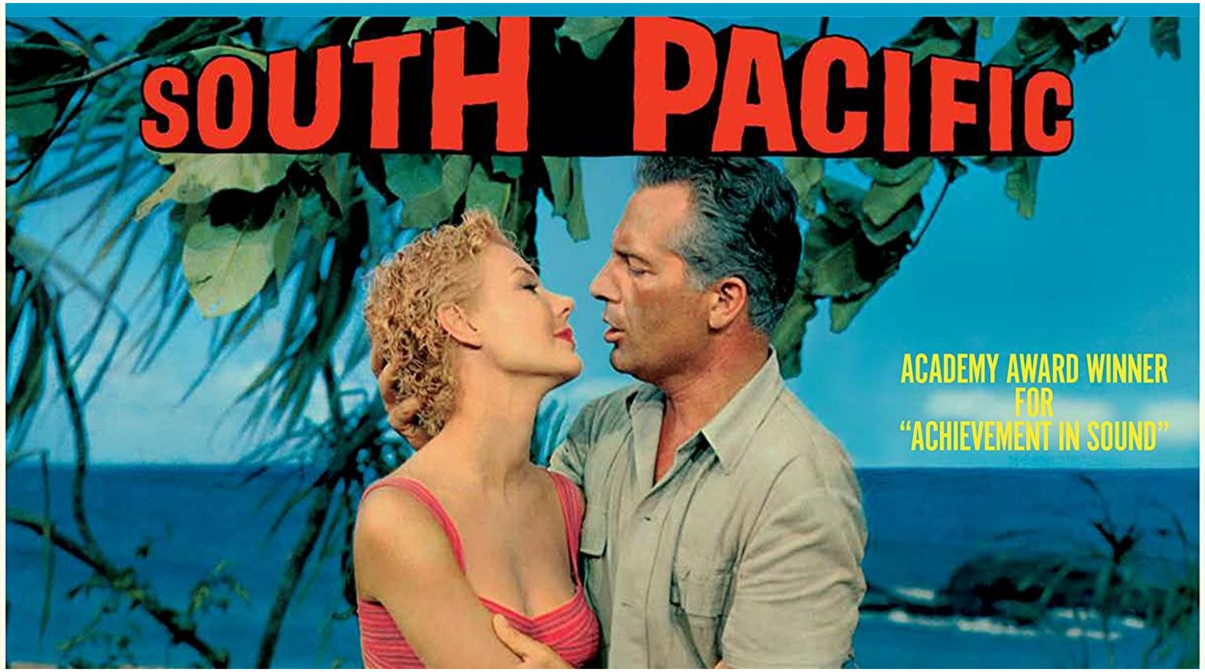
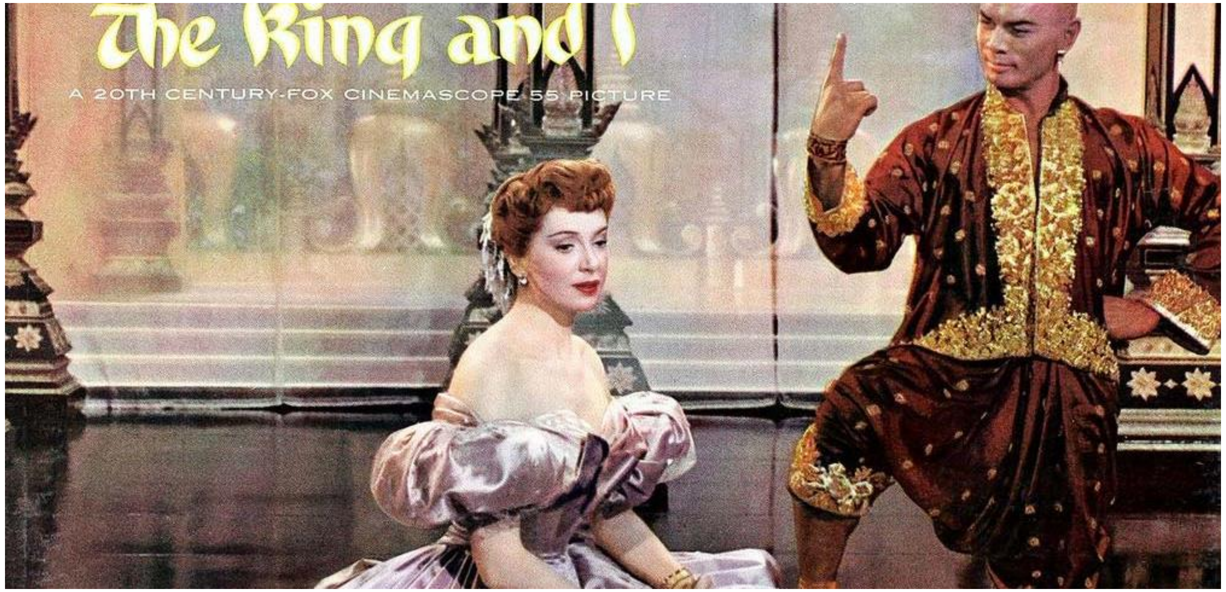

RODGERS AND HAMMERSTEIN'S
FLOWER DRUM SONG
IN COLOR • LENSES BY PANAVISION®
STARRING
NANCY KWAN Star of "SUZIE WONG"
JAMES SHIGETA
JUANITA HALL • JACK SOO • BENSON FONG and MIYOSHI UMEKI
Directed by HENRY KOSTER • Screenplay by JOSEPH FIELDS • Produced by ROSS HUNTER • Music by RICHARD RODGERS

Source: https://rodgersandhammerstein.com/stills/flower-drum-song-1961-film/


SOUTH PACIFIC
ACADEMY AWARD WINNER FOR "ACHIEVEMENT IN SOUND"

Source: https://rodgersandhammerstein.com/production/south-pacific/1958-film/


The King and I
A 20TH CENTURY-FOX CINEMASCOPE 55 PICTURE

Source: https://rodgersandhammerstein.com/production/the-king-and-i/1956-motion-picture-film/

Original idea:

Plays: South Pacific, The King and I, The Sound of Music.

These plays are reflections of a post-World War II era in which cultural shifts in Asia and Europe were afoot. The cultural shifts *du jour* written in to these plays are salient, so too is the timeless observation that *love* is what inspires real change.

Final idea:

Plays: South Pacific, The King and I, Flower Drum Song.

These plays are reflections of a post-World War II era in which America’s foreign policy prescriptions of containment and integration permeated popular culture, promulgating stereotypes of Asian Americans that persist today.

This is how I got there…

COLD WAR ORIENTALISM
ASIA IN THE MIDDLEBROW IMAGINATION, 1945–1961
CHRISTINA KLEIN

Klein reviews Cold War history and its impact on R&H Plays

Truman Doctrine (1947): Containment of communism (e.g., China, USSR)

Open Door Policy (1940s): Integrate Chinese markets (Japanese, too)

Problem: How to convince Americans Asians are too dangerous to mix with genetically and ideologically, but safe enough to engage in commerce?

Solution: Advance containment and integration in entertainment…

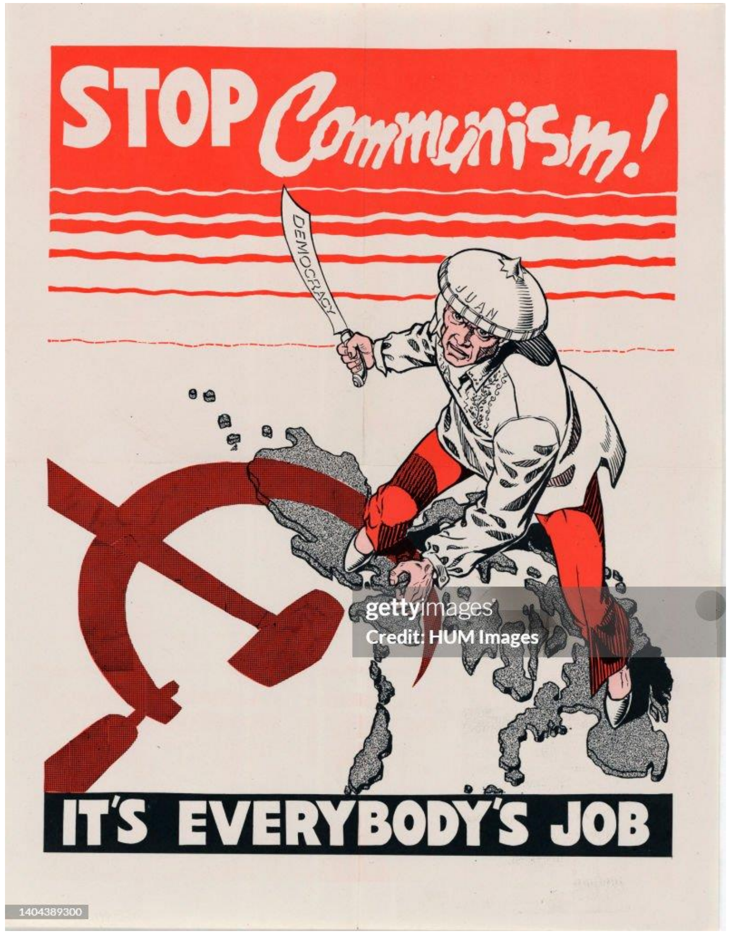
Themes featured in Flower Drum Song, South Pacific, and The King and I:

Containment: Asians are exotic and barbaric, not fit to mix genetics

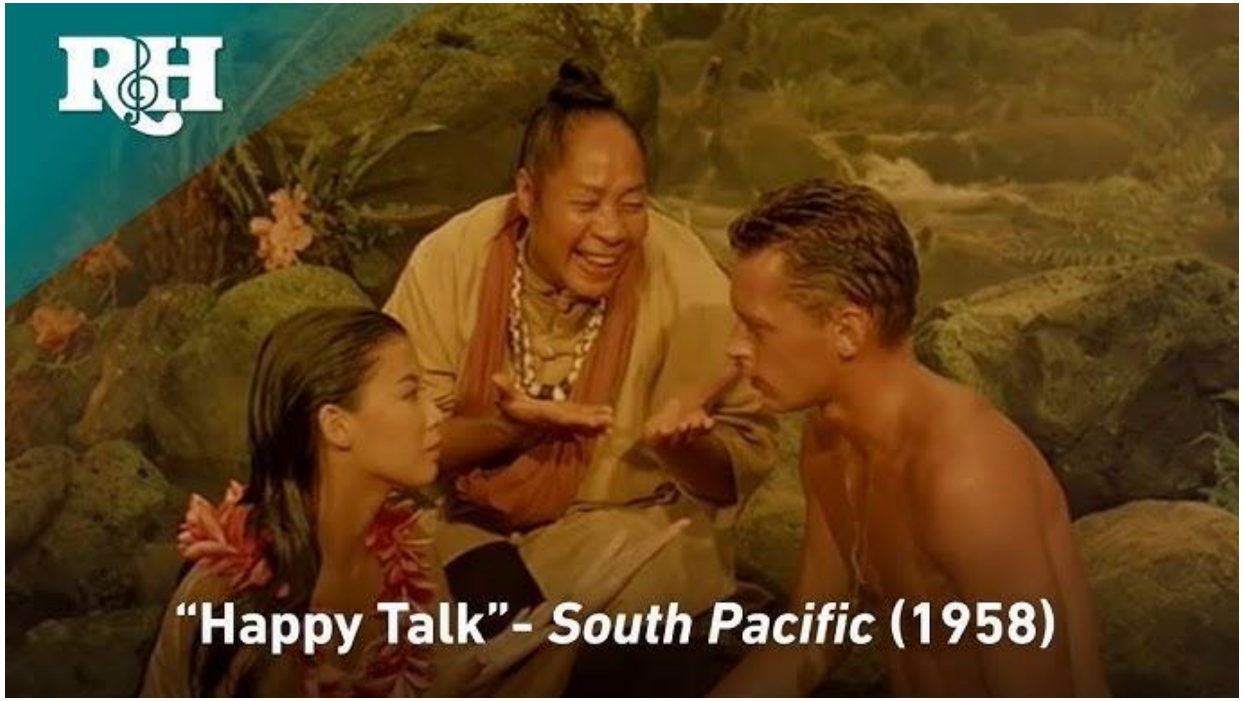
Integration: Asians can be redeemed through Western education

Cold War Events

- 1946
  - Second “Red Scare” begins (1946-1957)
  - March 6, Churchill delivers “The Sinews of Peace” speech (“Iron Curtain”)
  - March 21, U.S. forms the Strategic Air Command
- 1947
  - Truman Doctrine
  - McCarthy’s HUAC Hollywood hearings (again in 1951)
- 1948, Berline Blockade begins (ends 1949)
- 1949
  - Mao assumes control of China
  - South Pacific, Broadway
- 1950, Korean War begins
- 1951
  - Julius and Ethel Rosenberg convicted (executed 1953)
  - The King and I, Broadway
- 1953
  - Death of Stalin
  - Korean War ends
  - Cuban revolution begins
- 1955, U.S. begins support of South Vietnamese
- 1957, Sputnik 1 launched into orbit
- 1958, Flower Drum Song, Broadway


STOP Communism!
DEMOCRACY
JUAN
IT'S EVERYBODY'S JOB
gettyimages
Credit: HUM Images
1404389300

Source: https://www.gettyimages.com/detail/news-photo/propaganda-posters-in-1950s-asia-8-13-1951-u-s-propaganda-news-photo/1404389300



Source: https://youtu.be/JXgmQDFhPjo

Source: https://www.rebeatmag.com/not-how-it-seems-south-pacific-1958/

“You’ve Got to Be Carefully Taught”: The Politics of Race in Rodgers and Hammerstein’s *South Pacific*

Andrea Most

South Pacific (1949), 1,925+ performances, feature film

Containment

- **American Saviors**
  - Save the Bali Hai Polynesians from Japanese imperialism
- Lt. Joe Cable & Liat
  - Cable entranced by **Liat’s exoticness** and **sexuality**
  - Cable is killed off before he commits an act of **miscegenation**
- Nellie & Emile
  - Nellie is entranced by Emile’s anti-fascist French sophistication
  - Nellie confirms **anti-fascism ≠ communism**
  - Nellie breaks off the relationship b/c **racism** (Emile has two Polynesian children)

Integration

- Nellie reconciles with Emile, vowing to **teach** his **Polynesian children**, which is okay because Emile is a white European, a form of containment and integration

Source: http://www.filmsufi.com/2017/03/the-king-and-i-walter-lang-1956.html

Source: http://www.filmsufi.com/2017/03/the-king-and-i-walter-lang-1956.html

The "Oriental" Musicals of Rodgers and Hammerstein and the U.S. War in Southeast Asia

Bruce A. McConachie

The King and I (1951), 1,246+ performances, feature film

Containment

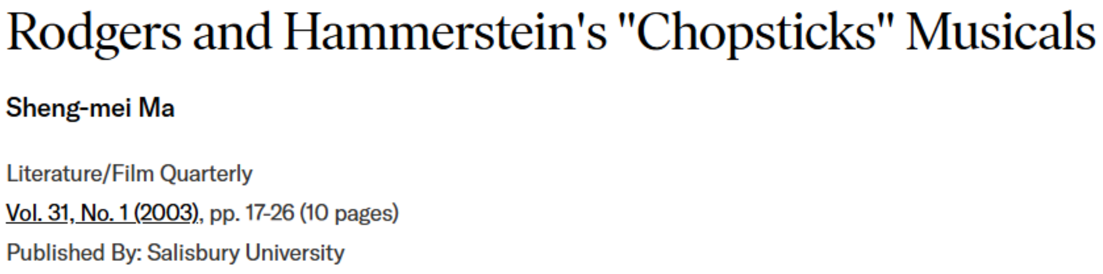
- The **King of Siam** is a brute and a child who is **starved for Western education**
- **Anna's teaching civilizes** the people of **Siam**, saving them from British occupation
- After witnessing the King's brutality, Anna threatens to leave Siam
- The King, despairing a life without his Western teacher, wills himself to death

Integration

- The Kings child-son assumes control, shows he has learned from Anna: bowing to the King is revoked
- Note: the harem, torture, slavery are still okay

Source: https://www.screenedword.com/post/flower-drum-song

Source: https://rodgersandhammerstein.com/song/flower-drum-song/the-other-generation/



Rodgers and Hammerstein's "Chopsticks" Musicals

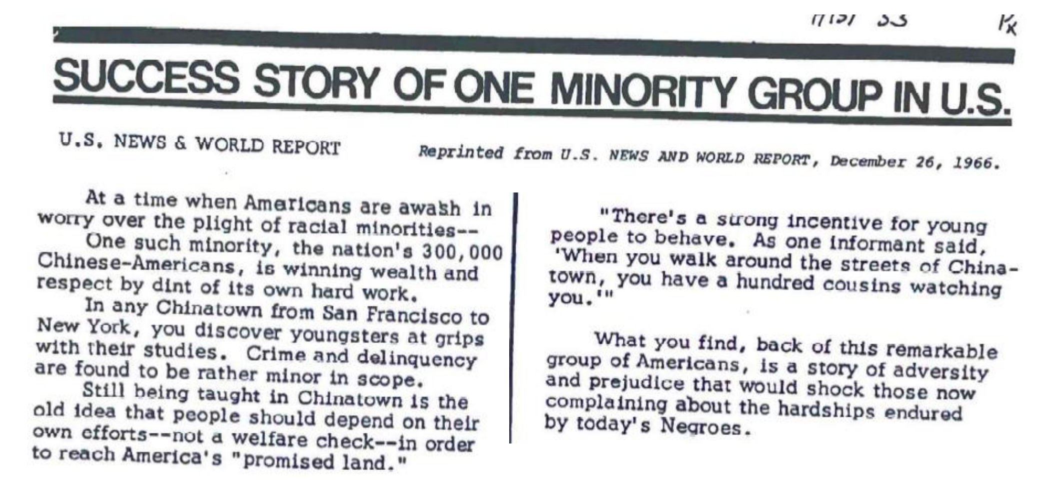
Sheng-mei Ma

Literature/Film Quarterly
Vol. 31, No. 1 (2003), pp. 17-26 (10 pages)
Published By: Salisbury University

Flower Drum Song (1958), 600 performances, feature film

Integration w/ light containment

- First all “Asian” cast in a play / movie
- The father, Wang Chi-yang exists to be **educated about American ways**
  - Madam Liang constantly reminds Chi-yang “**This is not China**”
- **Hyper sexualized** role of Linda Low
  - I Enjoy Being a Girl:
    My silhouette is curvey
    My hips kinda swively and swervy
- The happiest characters are enculturated: Western educated, entrepreneurial, dance the waltz, embrace materialism.
- Essentially: **Model citizens** isolated to China town



11131 33 Pk

SUCCESS STORY OF ONE MINORITY GROUP IN U.S.

U.S. NEWS & WORLD REPORT

Reprinted from U.S. NEWS AND WORLD REPORT, December 26, 1966.

At a time when Americans are awash in worry over the plight of racial minorities--

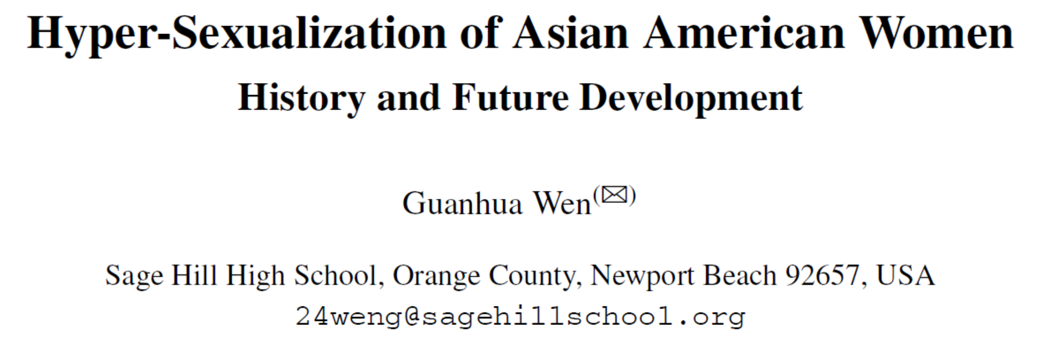
One such minority, the nation's 300,000 Chinese-Americans, is winning wealth and respect by dint of its own hard work.

In any Chinatown from San Francisco to New York, you discover youngsters at grips with their studies. Crime and delinquency are found to be rather minor in scope.

Still being taught in Chinatown is the old idea that people should depend on their own efforts--not a welfare check--in order to reach America's "promised land."

"There's a strong incentive for young people to behave. As one informant said, 'When you walk around the streets of Chinatown, you have a hundred cousins watching you.'"

What you find, back of this remarkable group of Americans, is a story of adversity and prejudice that would shock those now complaining about the hardships endured by today's Negroes.

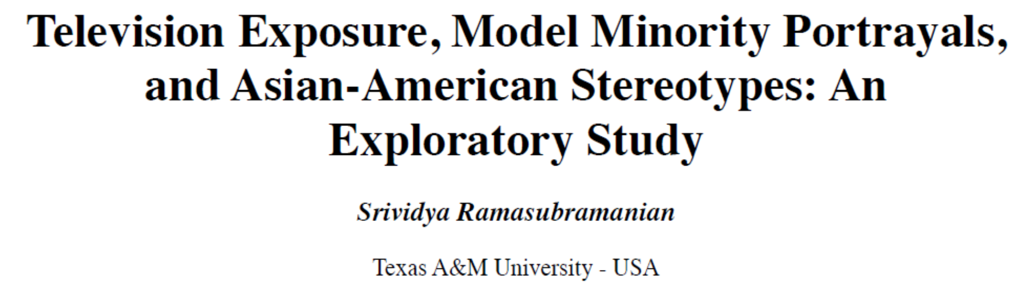


Hyper-Sexualization of Asian American Women

History and Future Development

Guanhua Wen(✉)

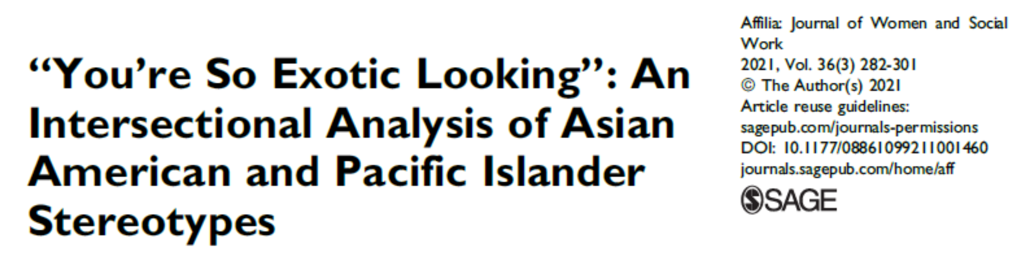
Sage Hill High School, Orange County, Newport Beach 92657, USA
`24weng@sagehillschool.org`



Television Exposure, Model Minority Portrayals, and Asian-American Stereotypes: An Exploratory Study

Srividya Ramasubramanian

Texas A&M University - USA



"You're So Exotic Looking": An Intersectional Analysis of Asian American and Pacific Islander Stereotypes

Affilia: Journal of Women and Social Work
2021, Vol. 36(3) 282-301
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Thank you for your time and attention!

Source: https://rodgersandhammerstein.com/production/the-king-and-i/1956-motion-picture-film/